He did not mention why it was not safe or where the danger would come from, but the following examples illustrate how the PNO's control and use of fear manifested in Pa-O villages.

During a field trip to Thathanshwe, a Pa-O village about one-and-a-half hour's drive from Taunggyi, the research team was forced to make a detour as part of the main road was closed for reasons unknown.[25] The car passed a village, and the team decided to pull over to interview some villagers about their views on development. This part of the fieldwork was therefore unscheduled, and the village selected was by chance. The villagers were asked to complete a questionnaire, which had been translated into Burmese and Pa-O. Initially, two villagers immediately agreed to complete the questionnaire and volunteered to ask more villagers to participate. They asked us to wait at the general store opposite while they gathered more villagers. While waiting, a large man in his forties introduced himself as the owner of the general store and offered the team drinks. In subsequent conversation, it transpired that he was the PNO-appointed village tract leader. After explaining the purpose of the stop over, he became uneasy and said he would not complete the questionnaire as it might be "unfair to other villages", and he refused to continue with the interview. By this time the two villagers who volunteered to recruit more people had returned with about seven villagers. The village tract leader said a few words to them and they all refused to do the questionnaire. The first two villagers had expressions of reluctance and fear on their faces.

Fieldwork conducted between June 2014 and March 2015 covered nine Pa-O villages. In all nine villages, the village headmen shared one thing in common: they all owned the general store. In the case of a larger village where there is more than one general store, the village head ran the biggest. During the fieldwork three village tract leaders were also encountered and they all had cars, which distinguishes them as local elites, because ordinary villagers have to walk for hours on rugged dusty roads to go to the market. Where did the village tract leaders find the money to buy cars? Under the Ward and Village Tract Administration Law the tract leaders are entitled to token remuneration, but it is definitely not sufficient to maintain, let alone buy, a car.

A clue may lie in the answer one village tract leader gave when asked about whether village headmen were paid for their jobs. According to him, the village headman was paid if he helped to settle issues. He gave two examples. If a thief is caught in a village, depending on the value of